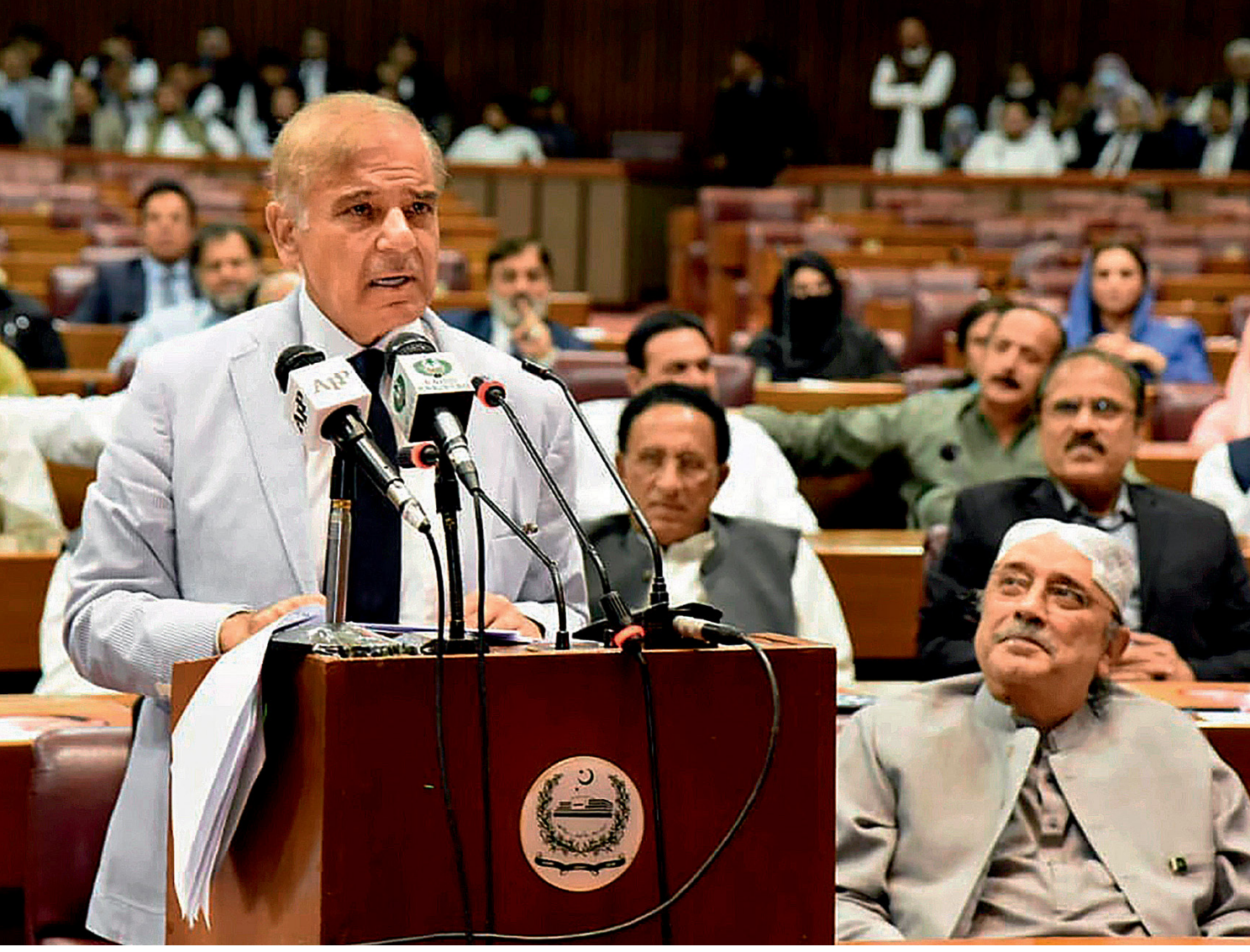


COMETH THE HOUR...
Pakistani prime minister Shehbaz Sharif addresses the National Assembly on April 11

While Shehbaz lacks the charisma of his elder brother—his oratory is often said to be dour and forced—he has cultivated a reputation as a 'man of action', a pragmatist and a hands-on administrator. In his last stint as chief minister of Pakistan's most populous province, from 2013 to 2018, the Chinese once praised his ability to get things done quickly by dubbing his style of governance as "Punjab speed". In his first address to parliament after being elected, Shehbaz attempted to strike a note of optimism—he promised to go all out to put Pakistan's economy back on track, to improve relations with the world, including India and, in a pointed reference to the overthrown Imran Khan, to be a leader who would bring Pakistanis together, rather than dividing them. But he knows he holds a poisoned chalice.

UNCERTAINTIES FACING SHEHBAZ'S GOVERNMENT

First of all, it is not clear how long this current dispensation will last. Officially, the remainder of this parliament's term is until August 2023. And while some senior PML-N leaders such as former premier Shahid Khaqan Abbasi indicate that they will attempt to pull through till then, given the political instability being threatened by the ousted Imran Khan, it would be a risky to wager against an early election.

SHEHBAZ HAS TO HOLD HIS UNWIELDY COALITION TOGETHER. POWER CREATES ITS OWN DYNAMICS. TAKING EVERYONE ALONG MAY BE DIFFICULT.

The Election Commission of Pakistan has indicated that it needs a minimum of seven months to hold an election, because of delayed constituency delimitations after the last census. Polls, thus, can't take place before October, but could happen any time beyond that.

November 2022 is when the current army chief, Gen.